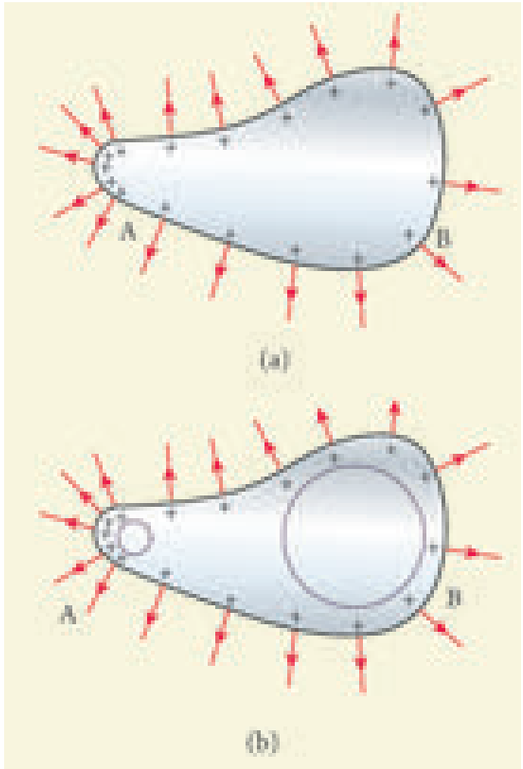


Figure 1.61 Action of points or corona discharge

We know that smaller the radius of curvature, the larger is the charge density. The end of the conductor which has larger curvature (smaller radius) has a large charge accumulation as shown in Figure 1.61 (b).

As a result, the electric field near this edge is very high and it ionizes the surrounding air. The positive ions are repelled at the sharp edge and negative ions are attracted towards the sharper edge. This reduces the total charge of the conductor near the sharp edge. This is called action of points or corona discharge.

1.9.3 Lightning arrester or lightning conductor

This is a device used to protect tall buildings from lightning strikes. It works on the principle of action at points or corona discharge.

This device consists of a long thick copper rod passing from top of the building to the ground. The upper end of the rod has a sharp spike or a sharp needle as shown in Figure 1.62 (a) and (b).

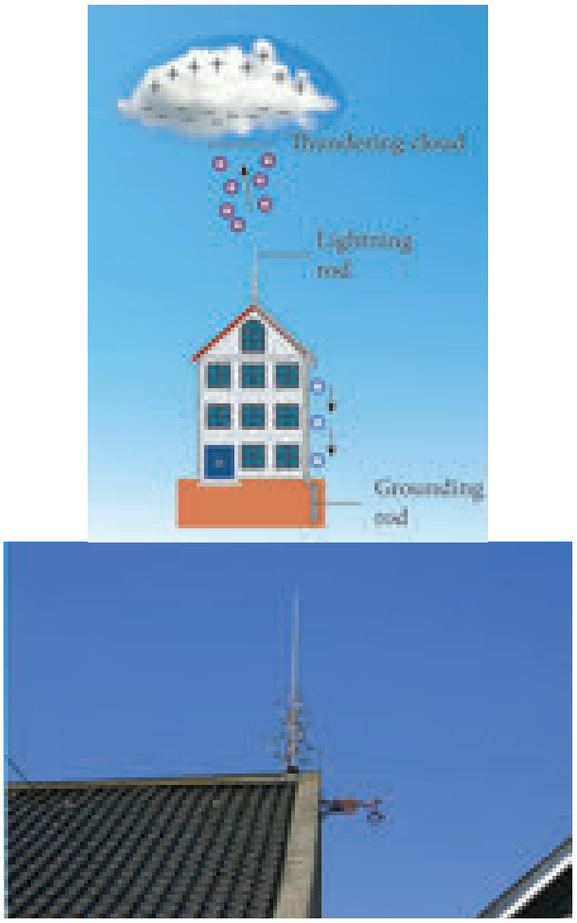


Figure 1.62 (a) Schematic diagram of a lightning arrestor. (b) A house with a lightning arrestor

The lower end of the rod is connected to copper plate which is buried deep into the ground. When a negatively charged cloud is passing above the building, it induces a positive charge on the spike. Since the induced charge density on thin sharp spike is large, it results in a corona discharge. This positive charge ionizes the surrounding air which in turn neutralizes the negative charge in the cloud. The negative charge pushed to the spikes passes through the copper rod and

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